

ORDER AT MCDONALD'S: ADVANCED ENGLISH

It's time we return to the delicious world of advanced English and order some McDonald's! Yup, we're spicing up our language learning by transforming a simple fast-food order into a rich linguistic feast. This PDF is stacked with advanced terms and grammar structures. But this lesson isn't just about food—it's about savouring the flavours of English. So, I hope you have an appetite for learning because there is plenty to study on today's menu!

How to order your burger at C1!

Now, I know what the comment section is going to be like in this video.



"Lucy, I'll never order in McDonald's like this!"

No, you won't.

In my video about ordering a coffee, I said that someone would probably spit in my drink if I ordered it like that. And the same is true here — **do NOT do this to the workers in McDonald's.**

But today's video is jam-packed with advanced vocabulary and grammatical structures that we genuinely use (just not in this context), and I think it's a really fun way to learn them.

By the way, my go-to order is a cheeseburger with fries and a Coke.



LEVEL 1

Can/Could/May I have a cheeseburger, medium fries and a large Coke, please?

This is actually how I order in McDonald's.

I covered the differences between using different **modal verbs** in my video about ordering a coffee, so if you're interested, go and watch that.

You might notice that I ordered **fries** /fraɪz/, not **chips** /tʃɪps/, even though in the UK, we normally say chips. In McDonald's, we go American and we ask for fries.

We order **Coke** /kəʊk/, not **cola**.

We are also often asked, "**Eat in or take away?**" which is asked to find out if you are eating in the restaurant or taking the food somewhere else. In the US, you're more likely to hear "**Eat in/For here or to go?**"

LEVEL 2

What I'd love is a well-done cheeseburger with a finely sliced, perfectly melted piece of cheese and a dab of ketchup; freshly made, lightly salted fries; and a large Coke with two cubes of almost-defrosted ice, please.

First, I want to touch on the grammar.

I started with **a cleft sentence**, "What I'd love is..."



We use cleft sentences **to place the emphasis on a certain part** (in this case, I was emphasising a **well-done cheeseburger**).

And that brings me to the next grammar point: **compound adjectives**.

Compound adjectives **have two or more words acting as a single descriptor**. Here are some examples from the text:

- **well-done** - /ˌwel 'dʌn/
- **finely sliced** - /ˌfaɪnli 'slaɪst/
- **perfectly melted** - /ˌpɜːfɪktli 'meltɪd/
- **freshly made** - /ˌfreʃli 'meɪd/
- **lightly salted** - /ˌlaɪtli 'sɔːltɪd/
- **almost-defrosted** - /ˌɔːlməʊst diː'frɒstɪd/

As you can see, some are **separated by hyphens** (well-done, almost-defrosted), and **others are not** (finely sliced, perfectly melted, etc.).

Lucy's Tip!

- **Hyphenate** compound adjectives when they come before a noun (*usually*).
- **Don't hyphenate** compound adjectives when the first word ends in -ly.

Next, I have two pieces of vocabulary I want to touch on:

I asked for a **dab** of ketchup.

- **dab** *n* /dæb/ - a small amount of something
*I applied a **dab** of cream to my sunburn to soothe my skin.*

Dab can also be used as a verb.

- **to dab** v /dæb/ - to gently touch a surface with something soft
I dab on make-up.

And I wanted the ice cubes **almost-defrosted**.

- **to defrost** v /di:'frɒst/ - to become warmer so it's not frozen any more
*Remember **to defrost** the frozen peas before adding them to the soup.*

Finally, I want to talk about the **punctuation** I used in that sentence. Did you notice that I used semicolons to separate the items in my order?

We can **use semicolons to separate items in a list if at least one of the items already contains a comma**. These two items had commas:

- *a well-done cheeseburger with a finely sliced, perfectly melted piece of cheese*
- *freshly made, lightly salted fries*

Semicolons are really good at helping avoid confusion in long lists.

LEVEL 3

If I may, I would like to ask for a well-done burger topped with a piece of cheese that is on the point of melting, a hint of gherkin and just a dollop of ketchup. I've also got a craving for some gently salted fries with a golden hue, though under no circumstances should they be burnt. And nothing would quench my thirst more than a Coke with crushed ice.



First, I want to talk about the structure I used to begin my order: **If I may**. It's a **very polite way to begin or end a request**. *I'd love a cookie, if I may.*

Next, there are two grammatical structures I want to talk about. The first is **on the point of**. This is a phrase to **express that something is about to happen in the very near future**.

Another structure is in this sentence: **under no circumstances should they be burnt**. *What do you notice about the word order?*

This sentence contains **inversion** - **when the verb comes before the subject** - **should they**, but it's not a question. It's an example of **inversion after a negative adverbial** - **under no circumstances**.

And now, some vocabulary:

I asked for a **hint** of **gherkin**.

- **hint** *n* /hɪnt/ - a very small amount of something
*There was a **hint** of jasmine in the air, making the garden smell delightful.*
- **gherkin** *n* /'gɜːkɪn/ - a small cucumber that is preserved in vinegar
*We served small **gherkins** as a part of the cheese platter.*

also called a **pickle** /'pɪkl/ in the States

There's a building in London
that everyone calls The Gherkin!



Here are a few more vocabulary terms for you:

- **craving** *n* /'kreɪvɪŋ/ - a strong desire for something
*Late at night, he often gets a **craving** for salty snacks like popcorn.*
- **hue** *n* /hju:/ - a colour or shade of a colour
*Deliah chose a soft blue **hue** for the walls of her bedroom.*
- **to quench one's thirst** *phrase* /kwentʃ wʌnz θɜːst/ - to drink until one doesn't feel thirsty anymore
*In the scorching heat, nothing seemed better than a cold iced tea **to quench my thirst.***
- **to top** *v* /tɒp/ - to place something on top of something else
*For the final touch, Mum decided **to top** the cake with fresh strawberries.*
- **dollop** *n* /'dɒləp/ - a little bit of soft food, typically spooned out in small portions
*She stirred a **dollop** of honey into her tea to sweeten it.*

LEVEL 4

Might I request a burger constructed of a chargrilled patty, a sliver of cheese that is more sharp than pungent, a gherkin with a bit of bite and a dab of ketchup? That should be served in a lightly toasted bun with a smattering of sesame seeds. I've also got a hankering for a generous serving of fries, which should be nicely crispy. In fact, so crispy should they be that I would like to hear a delicate crunch as I bite into each one. I'll top that all off with an ice-cold glass of Coke, please.



Oh, what a terrible customer.

First, I started with **Might I request...**, a very polite way to say 'Can I ask for...' or just 'Can I have...'.

I also used **an advanced comparative structure** - more sharp than pungent. To **compare two similar qualities**, we often use -

more + adjective + than + adjective

So I wanted it to be **sharp**, not ~~pungent~~.

And I used **inversion** again - **so crispy should they be that...** We use inversion when we have **so + adjectival/adverbial phrase** at the beginning of a sentence **for emphasis**.

We could rewrite it like this: **They should be so crispy that...**

Now for a bit of vocabulary!

- **to chargrill** v /'tʃɑ:grɪl/ - to cook something over a high heat so its surface is slightly burn
*Manny **chargrilled** the peppers until they were perfectly charred and tender.*
- **patty** n /'pæti/ - a piece of food made into a circular shape
*They made delicious chickpea **patties** as a vegetarian option at the BBQ.*
- **sharp** adj /ʃɑ:p/ - strong and a little bitter
*The mustard added a **sharp** bite to the sandwich, enhancing its taste.*
- **pungent** adj /'pʌndʒənt/ - having a very strong taste or smell
*The **pungent** aroma of garlic filled the kitchen as he cooked.*

- **smattering** *n* /'smætərɪŋ/ - a small number or amount
*There was only a **smattering** of people at the early morning market.*
- **to have a hankering for/to hanker after** *phrase* /hæv ə 'hæŋkərɪŋ fə/ / 'hæŋkə 'ɑ:ftə/ - to have a strong want or desire for something
*My daughter woke up and told me that she **had a hankering for** pancakes and syrup.*

And here are a few more terms for you that I didn't cover in the video.

- **sliver** *n* /'slɪvə/ - a small, thin piece cut or broken off from something larger
*A **sliver** of moonlight peeked through the curtains at night.*
- **with a bit of bite** *phrase* /wɪð ə 'bɪt əv 'baɪt/ - having a slightly sharp or spicy taste
*This salsa is mild but **with a bit of bite**; it's perfect!*

LEVEL 5

Were it not for my intense craving, I wouldn't be so specific. However, I would adore a cheeseburger made from meat that has been tenderised by hand before being fried. On top of that, I would like some tart cheese, a smidgen of mustard, a trace of ketchup and a perfectly round slice of gherkin. All of that should be in a bun encrusted with sesame seeds. On the side, I'd like some fries, which are to have been cooked to a perfect crisp and dusted with salt. And finally, I am going to abstain from drinking anything as I don't want to ruin my taste buds.



I am officially insufferable.

I began this order with a **conditional** sentence, which was another example of **inversion** — *it's everywhere today!*

Were it not for..., I wouldn't be...

This is a **second conditional**, in which the 'if clause' has been omitted, making the sentence **more formal**.

I also used a **perfect passive infinitive** structure: I'd like some fries, **which are to have been cooked** with the structure -

be + to have been + past participle

I used the passive here because I don't know who will cook the fries.

And finally, here is some of the vocabulary in that text.

- **tart** *adj* /tɑ:t/ - tasting sour or having a bitter taste
*The lemonade was a bit too **tart**, needing a touch more sugar.*
- **smidgen** *n* /'smɪdʒən/ - a small piece or amount of something
*I need just a **smidgen** more paint to cover this spot on the wall.*
- **encrusted** *adj* /ɪn'krʌstɪd/ - covered with something hard
*His boots were **encrusted** with mud after the long hike.*
- **to dust** *v* /dʌst/ - to cover something with a powdery substance
*The baker expertly **dusted** cinnamon over the apple pie.*
- **to abstain** *v* /əb'steɪn/ - to not do something, especially something pleasurable, that is bad for your health or wrong in some way
*People **abstain** from eating meat on certain days for religious reasons.*



Here are a few more that might help you further understand the text.

- **to tenderise** v /'tendəraɪz/ - to make meat softer before cooking it
To tenderise the chicken, he soaked it in buttermilk overnight.
- **taste bud** n /'teɪst bʌd/ - a small structure on the tongue that lets you taste different flavours
*Spicy foods can really excite your **taste buds**.*

QUIZ!

Choose the correct answer for each question.

1) What does 'tart' refer to in terms of taste?

- a. sweet
- b. salty
- c. sour or bitter

2) In the phrase 'almost-defrosted ice', what does 'defrost' mean?

- a. to freeze completely
- b. to melt
- c. to cool down

3) What does the word 'hankering' mean?

- a. a strong dislike
- b. a strong desire
- c. a mild preference

4) The fries should be _____ with salt.

- a. dusted
- b. soaked
- c. dolloped

5) There was a _____ of sesame seeds on my fingers after I finished the burger.

- a. heap
- b. encrusted
- c. smattering

6) What is the structure used in this sentence, "Seldom have I seen such a beautiful sunset."

- a. inversion after an adverbial
- b. passive voice
- c. subjunctive mood

7) "What she needs is a holiday," is an example of:

- a. a compound sentence
- b. a cleft sentence
- c. an imperative sentence

8) This sentence uses inversion in a conditional clause:
I'd prefer a tea, should it be available.

- a. True
- b. False

9) _____ I be excused from the meeting this afternoon?

- a. Might
- b. Shan't
- c. What shall

10) _____ he ever spoken to you about his plans.

- a. Rarely has
- b. Rarely have
- c. Has rarely

The End!

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